well calculated to promote their political interests,' he argued shrewdly. 'It is necessary that some change should take place in their religion, at least for the sake of their political advantage and social comfort.' [11]

Accordingly, Roy promoted a rational, ethical, non-hierarchical, and modern Hinduism, committed to ending the worst Hindu social practices of the day and streamlining Hindu theology. He founded a reform movement, the Brahmo Samaj, which was clearly a product of the interaction of his reformist ideas of Hinduism, emerging from a modernistic reading of Advaita Vedanta, with early-Victorian Christianity. The Brahmos rejected the idolatry that Hinduism had become synonymous with in British eyes and professed belief in a formless God, along with a monotheistic theology based on their reading of the *Upanishad*s and of the Vedanta, Hindu sacred texts that credibly lent themselves well to such a 'modern' interpretation. Brahmos affirmed their belief in the existence of One Supreme God—'a God, endowed with a distinct personality and moral attributes equal to His nature, and intelligence befitting the Author and Preserver of the Universe.' Brahmos would worship Him alone, and not necessarily in temples or at specific holy days: 'We can adore Him at any time and at any place, provided that time and that place are calculated to compose and direct the mind towards Him.'

In creating the Brahmo Samaj, Roy was strongly influenced by Unitarianism, whose uncompromising monotheism posited the oneness of God (in opposition to the Trinity of the Father, the Son and the Holy Ghost). Roy's attitude to Hinduism was in many ways comparable to the Unitarians' to Christianity, paring the faith of unnecessary accretions and reducing it to its most basic affirmations of deism. (Today, it is impossible to read of the beliefs of the Unitarian Universalists without being struck by their similarities to the central tenets of Upanishadic Hinduism.) Some Hindu scholars refused to consider Roy to be a Hindu at all, seeing in the Brahmo faith a form of Christianity dressed in Indian clothes. Others saw Roy as a staunch reformist within the Hindu faith: he wore a sacred thread all his life. But it would take a Vivekananda, not a Roy, to preach, seven decades later, a robust, modernist and universalist